Nonconformance and Hold Procedure

Purpose and Scope

This procedure defines how Riverbend Packaging identifies, segregates, evaluates, and dispositions product, material, or packaging that does not meet requirements. It prevents nonconforming product from reaching customers and ensures every event is documented and investigated.

Definitions

- **Nonconformance (NC):** Any product, material, or process result that fails to meet a specification or procedure.
- **Hold:** The physical and system segregation of suspect product until disposition.
- **Disposition:** The documented decision on what happens to held product: release, rework, sort, scrap, or return to supplier.

Roles

Role	Responsibility
Operator	Identify and report; apply hold tags
Line Lead	Stop the line when required; segregate product
Quality Engineer	Investigate; decide disposition
Plant Manager	Approve scrap above cost threshold
Maintenance Supervisor	Correct equipment causes

Initiating a Hold

1. Stop the line if the nonconformance is ongoing.
2. Notify the line lead and Quality immediately.
3. Identify the extent: determine the last known good check and the first suspect time.
4. Segregate all product between those two points, including pallets, partial pallets, and product in process.
5. Apply a red HOLD tag showing product, lot number, date, quantity, reason, and your name.
6. Move product to the designated hold area or mark it in place if moving is unsafe.
7. Enter the hold in the quality system and open an NC report.

NOTE: When in doubt, hold. Releasing held product is easy; recalling shipped product is not.

NC Report Contents

An NC report records the product and lot, quantity, specification violated, measured values, date and time, detection method, containment taken, and suspected cause.

Investigation

1. Review the process records around the event.
2. Interview operators and maintenance.
3. Identify the root cause using 5 Whys or fishbone analysis.
4. Determine whether other lots could be affected.
5. Define corrective and preventive actions with owners and due dates.

Disposition Options

Option	When used	Approval
Release	Product meets requirements after retest	Quality Engineer
Rework	Defect can be corrected and re-inspected	Quality Engineer
Sort	Defect can be found by 100 percent inspection	Quality Engineer
Scrap	Cannot be corrected or sorted	Quality Engineer; Plant Manager over cost limit
Return to supplier	Incoming material defect	Quality Engineer and Purchasing

Reworked product must be reinspected at an increased sample rate and traced to the original NC number.

Common Hold Triggers

Trigger	Typical scope of hold
Cap torque outside action limits	Product since the last good torque check
Fill weight below lower spec	Product since the last in-control check
Glass breakage on the line	Product near the breakage area
Chemical contact with product	All exposed product
Metal detector reject	Product since last good test

Closing the NC

The NC is closed when the disposition is complete, the corrective action is verified effective, and records are filed. Quality reports open NCs older than 30 days at the weekly quality meeting.

Records

NC reports are retained for three years. Trends, such as repeated torque holds or repeated fill-weight holds, are reviewed monthly and fed into continuous improvement projects. Documentation conflicts discovered during investigations are reported to the document owners for correction.

Escalation and Communication

Any nonconformance that could affect food safety, regulatory compliance, or shipped product is escalated to the Plant Manager within one hour. The Quality Engineer decides whether customers must be notified and documents the decision. Shift supervisors brief the next shift on all open holds so that held product is not moved or shipped by mistake. Held product is never used for sampling, trials, or testing without a documented

Quality approval, and hold tags may only be removed by the Quality Engineer or a designee.